

A

Formation

A phrasal verb is a verb + adverb or preposition, and sometimes a verb + adverb *and* preposition.

He **fell over** [fell to the ground] and hurt his knee.

I'll try to **find out** [learn/discover] the quickest way to get there.

He didn't like his coat, so he **gave it away** [gave it to someone for no money].

If you don't understand the meaning, **look it up** [find the meaning in a book/dictionary].

Who's going to **sort out** the problem? [deal with it successfully; solve it]

He doesn't **get on with** [have a good relationship with] his parents. (verb + adv. + prep.)

B

Meaning

The adverb or preposition does not always change the meaning of the verb, and is not always used.

I didn't **wake (up)** until 7 o'clock.

She's **saving (up)** for a new computer.

Hurry (up) or we'll be late.

I went to **lie (down)** on the bed.

Sometimes an adverb adds a particular meaning to the verb. For example, **back** can mean *return*.

I bought this jacket yesterday, but I'm going to **take it back** to the shop; it's too small.

You can look at the books, but remember to **put them back** on the shelf.

They liked Greece so much they want to **go back** next year.

Often, the adverb or preposition changes the meaning of the verb: *give up* doesn't mean the same as *give*, and *carry on* doesn't mean the same as *carry*.

My wife has decided to **give up** [stop] smoking.

We'll take a short break and then **carry on** [continue] with the meeting.

The shops are going to **put up** [increase] the price of bread.

When the hotel gets busy, we have to **take on** [employ] more staff.

C

Multiple meanings

Many phrasal verbs have more than one meaning.

go away

I was busy, so I told him to **go away** [leave].

We try to **go away** in August. [go on holiday]

Pick something /someone up

I **picked up** most of the rubbish. [lifted it from the floor]

I'm going to **pick Jane up** at the station. [collect someone, usually in a car]

Put something on

Could you **put the light on** [make a piece of equipment work by pressing a switch; *syn* **switch sth on**]?

I **put on** my best suit. [put clothes on your body]

